

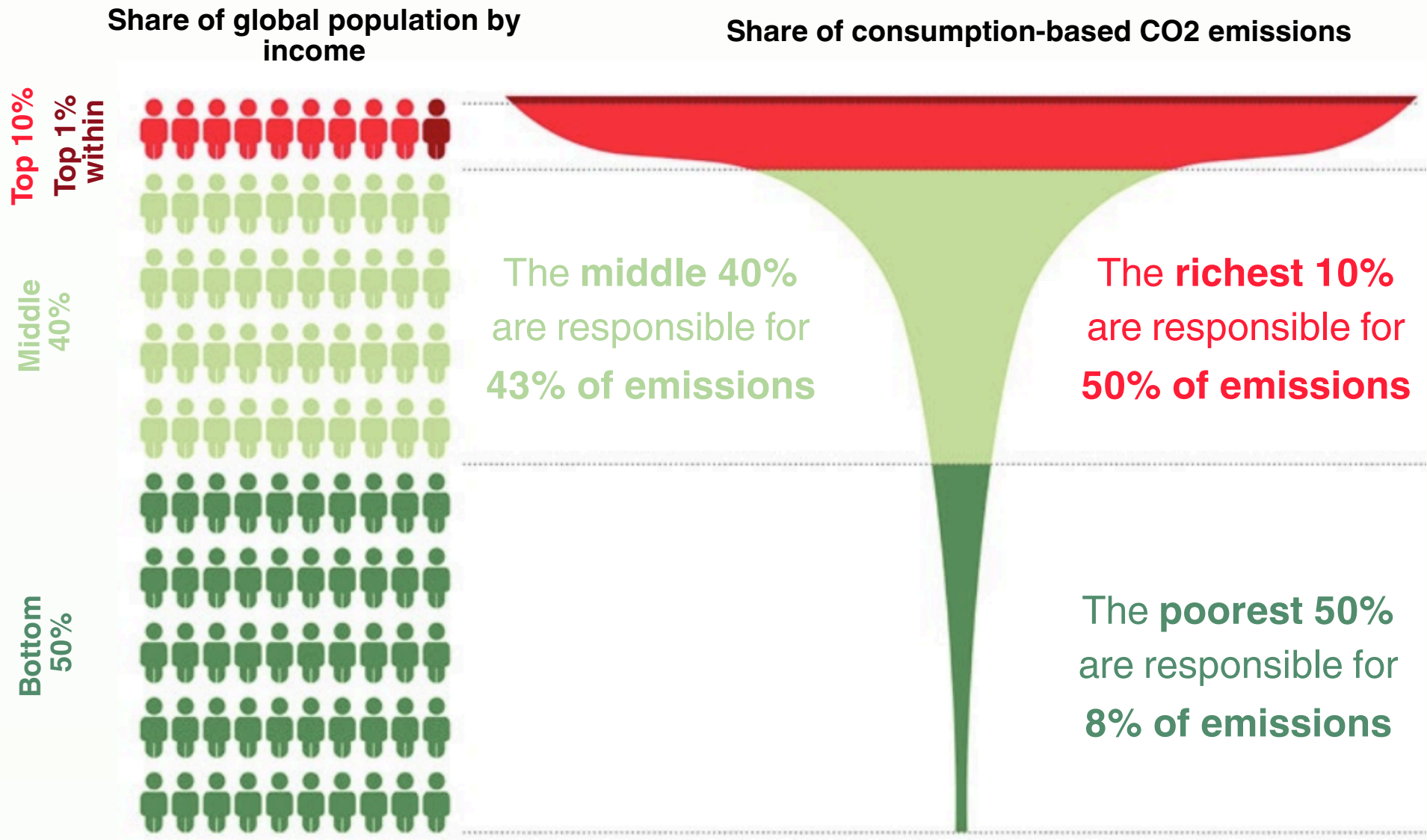
Climate Injustice : The World's Richest People Have an Outsized Role in Climate Extremes

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I. WHO ARE THEY ?

What is the share of emissions by wealth group?

Global income groups and associated consumption emissions in 2019



What if everyone emitted at the same level ?

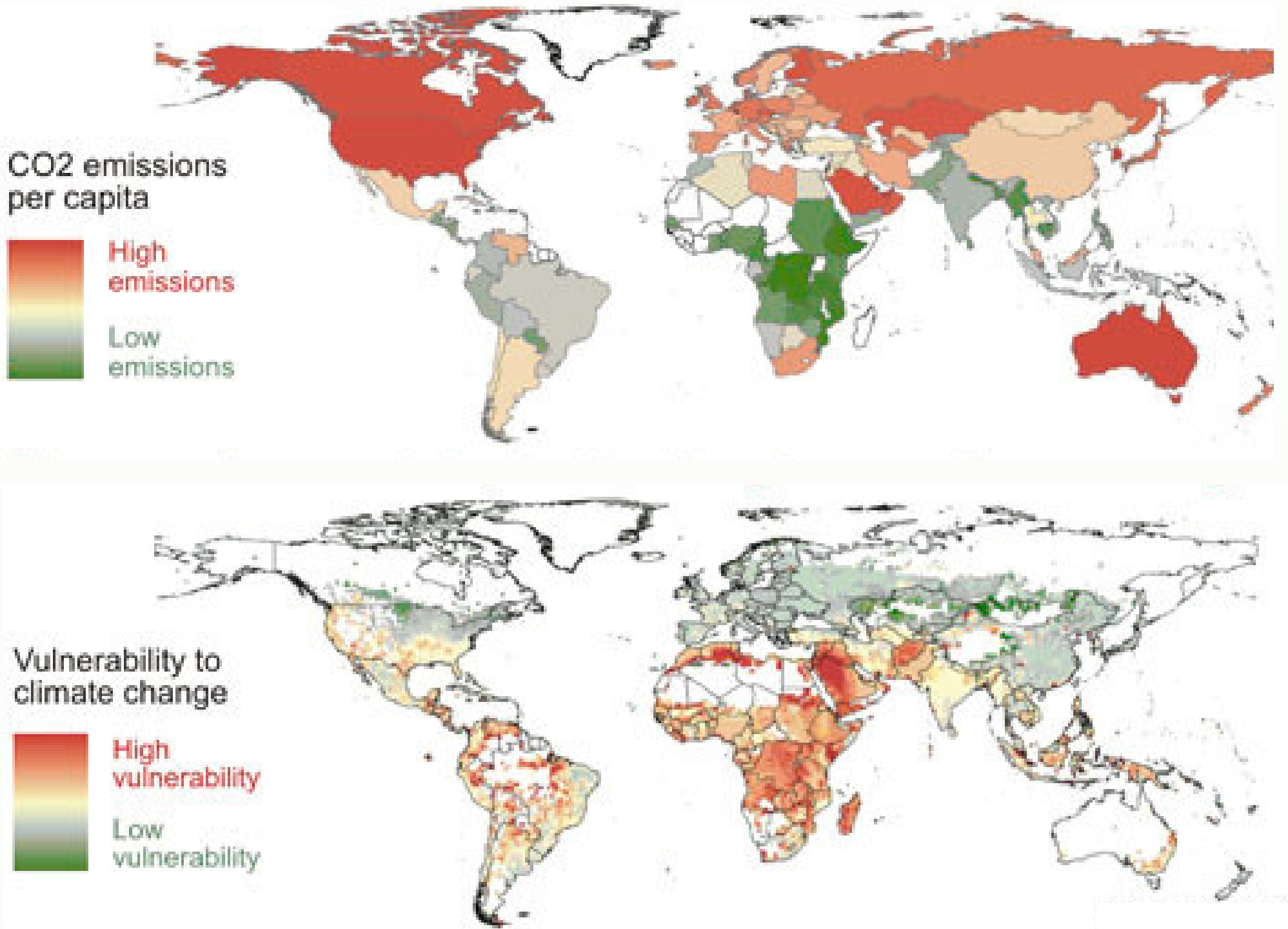
Temperature increase since 1990 if everyone emitted at the same level

~0°C → bottom 50%
+ 2.9°C → top 10%
+ 6.7°C → top 1%
+ 12.2°C → top 0.1%

Source : Sarah Schöngart et al, 2025

II. GLOBAL DISPARITIES

Between-country inequality



Source : Samson et al 2011

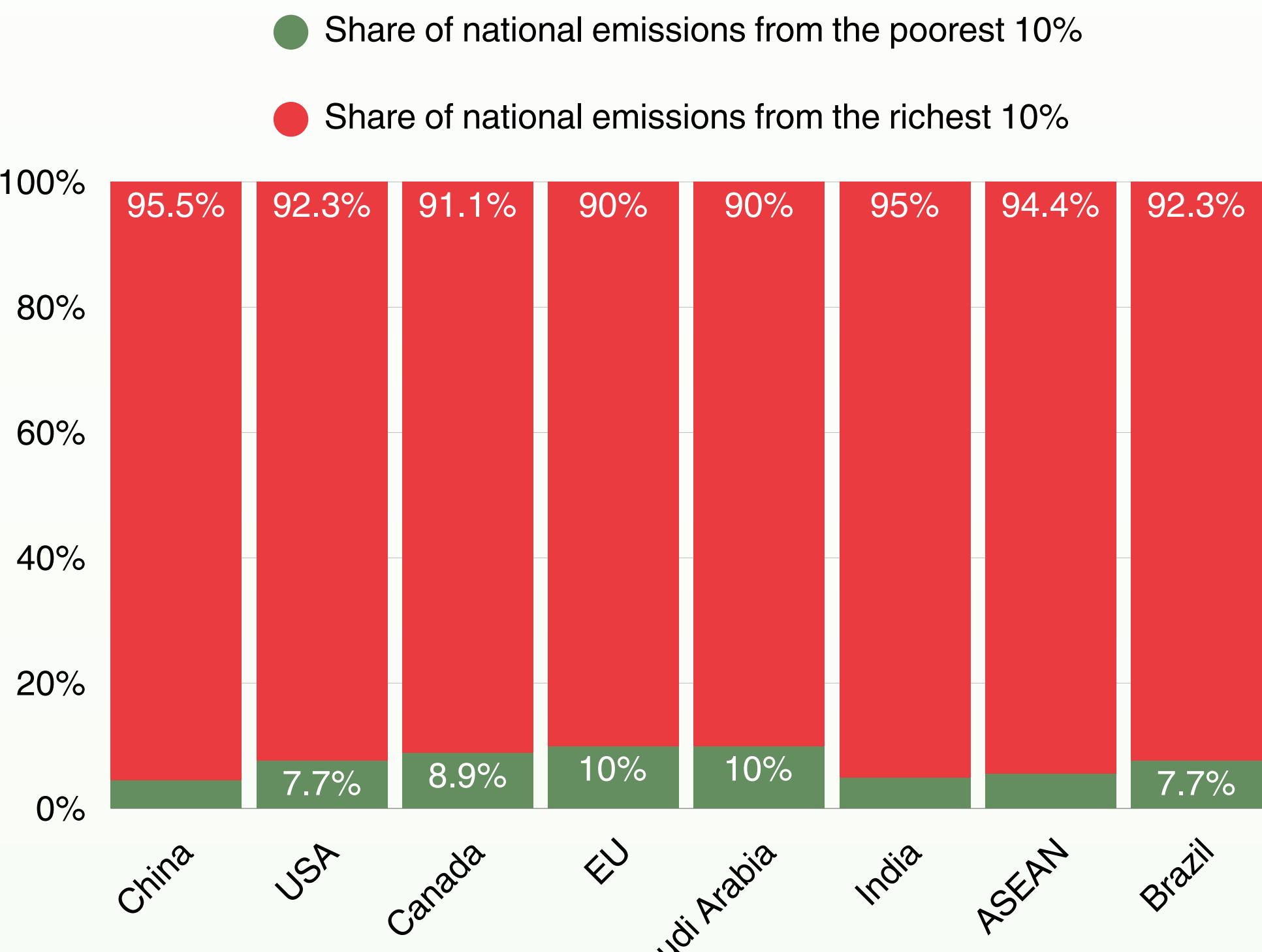
- Largest emitters: **North America, Europe, and China**
- Lowest emitters: The **Global South** (including Africa, South Asia, and Latin America)

→ Those who contribute the least greenhouse gases will be most impacted by climate change

Within-country inequality

- Even inside the same country, emissions are extremely unequal. Today, **63% of global carbon inequality happens inside countries**, not between them.

Share of national CO₂ emissions of the richest vs poorest 10% across countries (Relative CO₂ footprint index)

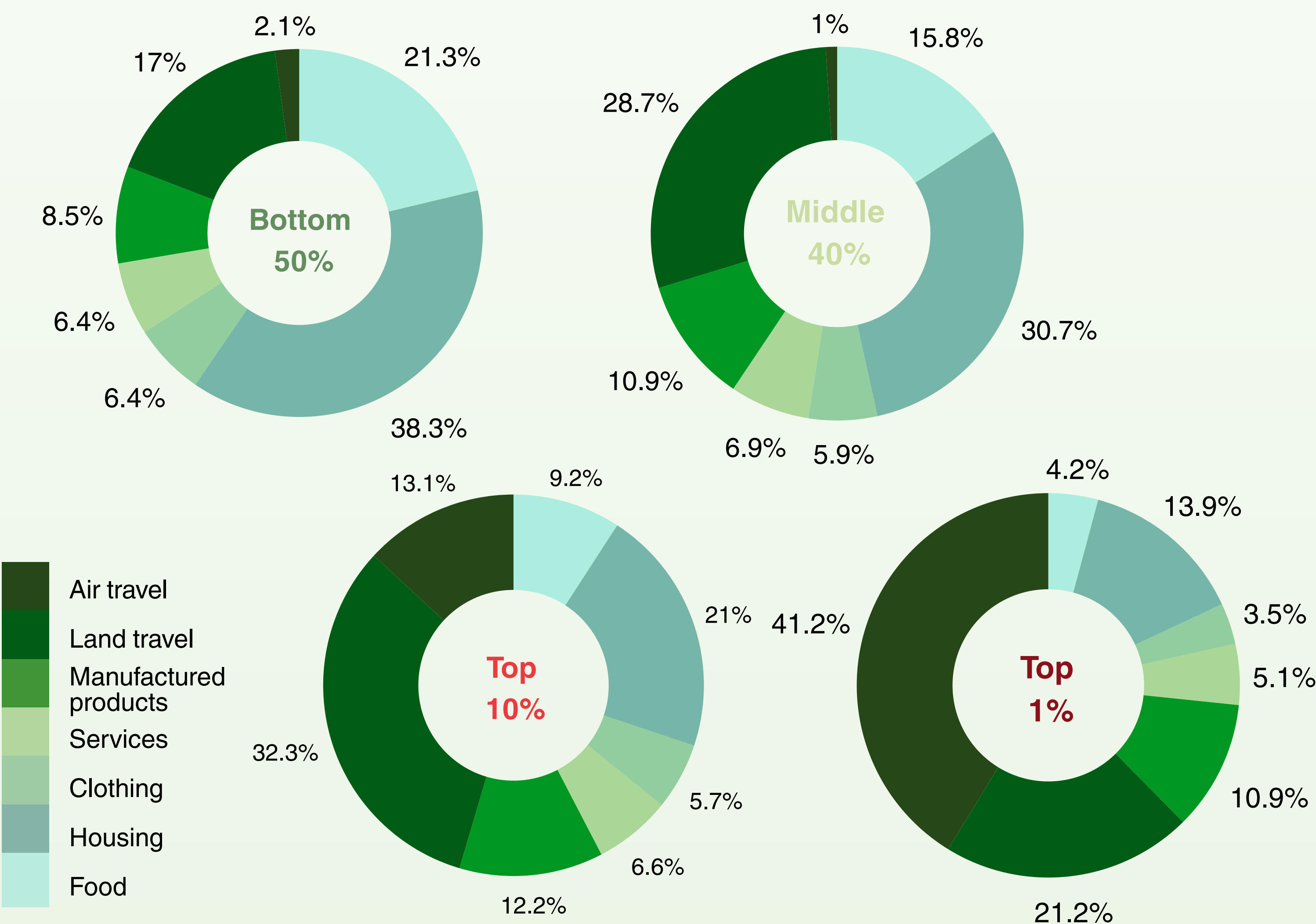


Arora et al., 2023. The Emissions Divide: Inequality Across Countries and Income Classes. Council on Energy, Environment and Water

III. HOW DO THEY POLLUTE?

Private consumption

Average carbon footprint (CF) distribution by consumption category in the European Union (EU) by bottom, middle or top emitters



Ivanova, D. and Wood, R. (2020) The unequal distribution of household carbon footprints in Europe and its link to sustainability'. Global Sustainability, 3, p. e18. doi:10.1017/sus.2020.12.

State-Enabled Pollution

Lack of regulation and taxation

- **No taxes on polluting investments** : fossil fuels and polluting sectors → little or no taxation, encouraging unsustainable finance.
- **Tax exemptions** : Loopholes and tax breaks, such as untaxed jet fuel or offshore assets

Sources : Le Monde, 2021 : Quand Jeff Bezos, Elon Musk et George Soros ne paient pas d'impôt sur le revenu ;

Parlement.ch, 2023 : Pas de taxe pour certains vols de jets privés et d'affaires

Political influence and lobbying

- **Lobbying and influence** : Use lobbying and campaign funding to shape policies in ones favor.
- **Participation in negotiations** : Fossil fuel industries often included in climate talks → leverage to block strong environmental measures.

Sources : OXFAM France, 2025 : Pillage climatique : comment une puissante minorité d'ultra-riches plonge le monde dans le chaos; BBC News Afrique, 2021 : Environnement : comment les riches contribuent au changement climatique

Prioritization of inequitable policies

- **Shift in responsibility** : costs of the ecological transition shifted to ordinary citizens instead of the biggest polluters
- **Lack of concrete alternatives** : Governments hesitate to promote low-carbon lifestyles or green infrastructure, fearing backlash from elites and voters.

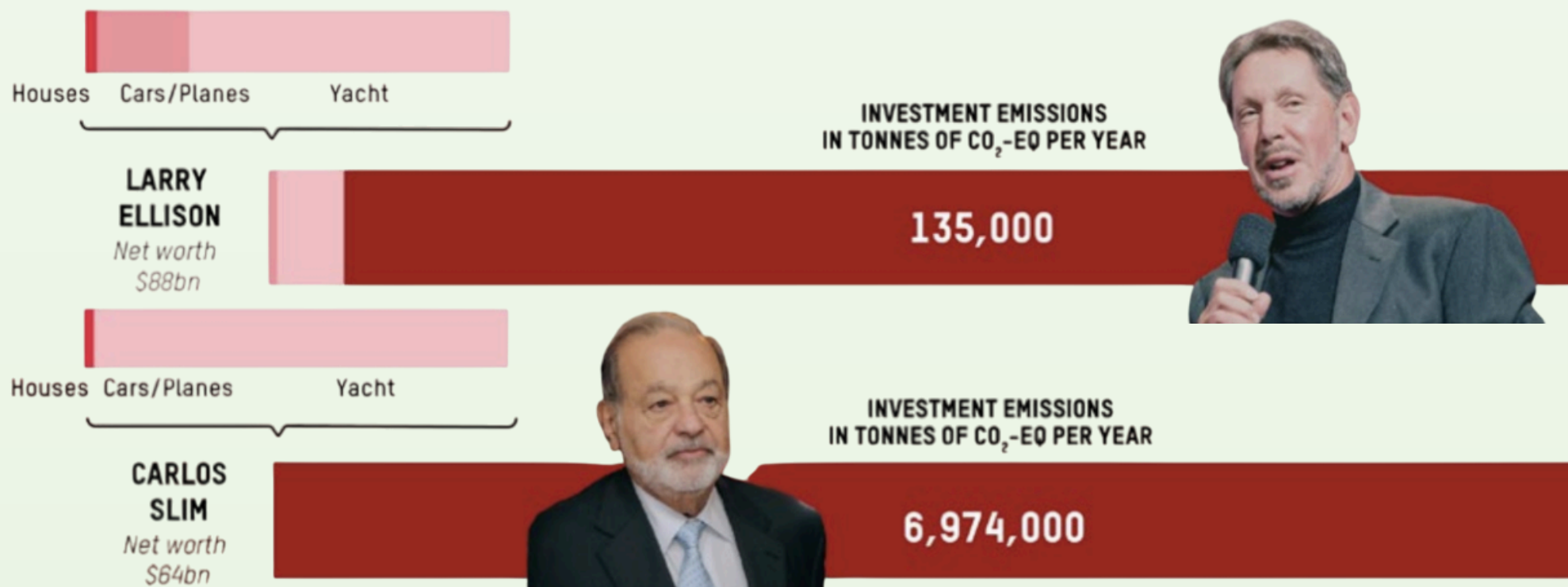
Source : OXFAM France, 2025 : Pillage climatique : comment une puissante minorité d'ultra-riches plonge le monde dans le chaos

Consumption vs investement emissions (in tons of CO₂-eq/year)

An example of 2 billionaires

For reference, the consumption emissions of the bottom 99% of the population is 4.1 tonnes CO₂ per person per year

Source : Oxfam, Barros and Wilde (2021)



IV. SOLUTIONS

How to hold the wealthiest accountable and finance a just transition to a sustainable economy?

A radical increase in equality

- Redistribution of land and investment in smallholder farmers
- Universal public services and social protection
- Living wages and trade union rights

Source : Oxfam, Barros and Wilde (2021)

A fast, just transition away from fossil fuels

- Wealth-based carbon taxes
- Divestment from fossil fuels
- Frequent-flyer levies

A new purpose for a new age

- Replace overconsumption with sobriety, solidarity, and sustainability
- Capital generated from policies redirected to fund transition
- Example : an income tax of 60% on the top 1% of earners would generate US\$ 6.4 trillion, which could be used to cover the vast climate finance needs of the Global South.

V. CONCLUSION

Key takeaway

- The **richest 10%** drive **most global emissions and planetary heating** through excessive consumption, luxury lifestyles, and political influence.
- **Carbon inequality** now exists within nations — the climate burden is both **local and global**.
- While the wealthy pollute freely, ordinary people bear the rising **costs of transition**.

- Consumption differ between rich and poor: **⅓ of the bottom 50%** is for **basic needs**, while **⅓ of the top 1%** is for **travel**.
- The **ultra-rich drive emissions** and avoid **accountability** through loopholes, lobbying, and weak regulation.
- Large **share of billionaires' CO₂ emissions** comes from **investments**.
- A **fair transition is possible** by **reducing inequality**, moving away from fossil fuels, and **rethinking prosperity**.

What percent of the world are you richer than?

Scan the QR code to discover where you stand relative to the world's richest groups :

